



▲ **The opening** of the Tōkaidō Shinkansen line was accompanied by an official ceremony at Japan National Railway's Tokyo station on 1 October 1964.

Fare thee well, steam

Diesel and electric power rapidly replaced steam during the post-war period as the latter was fast considered outmoded and dirty. Europe started seeing the last of the steam locomotives by the 1950s and the No. 23.105 rolled off the West German production line in 1959 as the last to be built for the Deutsche Bundesbahn. Electric locomotives had proved their usefulness in the Swiss and Austrian Alps in the early 20th century and after the war, the transition to electric trains in most European countries picked up speed. Significantly, in 1955, the French electric BB 9004 and CC 7107 set a new world record after reaching 331 km/h. The UK with its newly nationalized British Railways decided to continue using steam until after the publication of the Modernization Plan in the mid-1950s.